

In the good old days of the clickety-clack typewriter, nobody gave the keyboard a second glance. It came with the equipment, and that was about it. The arrival of the personal computer changed things drastically. So much so that even the 101-key keyboard is now passé. Newer multimedia keyboards sport as many as 22 hotkeys, and boast of aesthetic and ergonomic designs. They can cost as much as Rs 12,000, but you can pick up a regular keyboard for as little as Rs 300.

Important factors to be considered before purchasing a new keyboard include the comfort it gives you while typing, the layout of the keys on the device, tactile feedback, the presence or absence of a palm rest or wrist support, the number of hotkeys available, integrated trackballs and other mouse controls, the interface (USB or PS/2), and of course, overall build quality.

The popular brands in the market are Microsoft, Logitech, Samsung, Acer, Typhoon, Odyssey, Frontech, Gigabyte, Neotech, Vesta and Mercury. Prices begin

at a humble Rs 300 and touch the sky at Rs 5,000, so it all depends on the brand and the type. For instance, a wireless RF (Radio Frequency) keyboard could cost over Rs 4,500. A keyboard with a PS/2 interface, on the other hand, starts at just Rs 300.

Keyboards from Typhoon, Frontech and Neotech also have a built-in microphone, along with multimedia functional keys. Look for keyboards that accommodate extra function keys for increased productivity—

for surfing the Internet, running a CD audio player or opening the mailbox. However, these keyboards rely on software to run the different programs, and work with only certain operating systems.

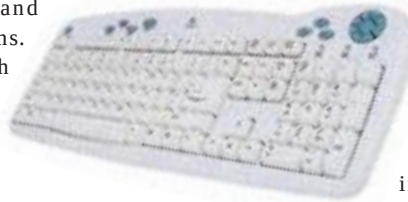
Cordless keyboards are also available, but at higher prices. These keyboards come with an incorporated touchpad (something that works like a mouse), saving a lot of space. If you consider an infrared keyboard, check for the type of battery the keyboard uses, as well as the average battery life. Further, these devices work only along the line of sight, which may be problematic for some users.

For users who are paranoid about security, there are identification keyboards with fingerprint verification. These allow you to lock and unlock your computer with a mere touch of your finger. However, they may be difficult to find in the market.

Keyboards come in different layouts—typing keys are generally laid out in the same style that was common for typewriters. Critics of the QWERTY layout (taken from the letters on the first line of the said keyboard) have adopted another layout, called Dvorak, which places the most commonly used letters in a more convenient arrangement. However, these may be difficult to use for people used to working on QWERTY keyboards.

AT-connector keyboards are sought after by users with older motherboards. You can find this keyboard with a PS/2 converter with a few vendors. This interface, anyway, does not apply to new computers.

As far as mice are concerned, critical factors that should be taken into account include the accuracy they provide in



Buying Tips for Keyboards

- The keyboard needs to be soft and smooth
- Leg pegs on the keyboard should be sturdy; most tend to break with the slightest of jerks.
- The keys should be tactile and not require too much pressure to register. Since it's in constant use, any glitch with the keyboard can be very irritating.
- An ergonomic keyboard is split in the middle, offsetting the keys where the two hands lie. This type of keyboard does take some time to get used to, especially since the arrow keys have been completely changed.
- Many vendors offer a combination of a keyboard and mouse in a cheap package deal. This is worth exploring.
- At the minimum, any Windows user should opt for a keyboard with a Windows shortcut key.
- Try to fit in a wrist pad that provides additional comfort and causes less strain on your wrists.